

Rutgers - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG TEN

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Fringe-bowl / lower-middle Big Ten quality; proven skill talent gives the offense a real ceiling, but defense and transition risk dominate the range.
Preseason consensus	AP unranked (0 votes/points) · SP+ No. 61
Returning production	47% (No. 92) overall · Off. 49% (No. 84) · Def. 46% (No. 90)
Primer power rating	+2.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	5.4 wins · most likely 5-7
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Similar - Similar, but more volatile
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: Kirk Ciarrocca can build around RB Antwan Raymond and WR KJ Duff with Boston College transfer QB Dylan Lonergan now the starter behind a reworked line. New DC Travis Johansen inherits a defense that must become more physical immediately, with transfer production up front but an extensively rebuilt secondary.

Bottom line: Proven offensive star power gives Rutgers a bowl path, but low returning production, an unproven QB1, unsettled OL roles and a near-total secondary rebuild support a five- to six-win profile.

Beats expectations if: Lonergan protects the ball, the rebuilt OL keeps Raymond/Duff productive, and Johansen gets immediate front-seven impact while the new secondary limits explosives.

Disappoints if: The QB/OL transition drags an otherwise proven skill group backward and a secondary replacing both 12-start corners, S Jett Elad and other veteran DB production remains one of the Big Ten's most exploitable units.

Five things to remember

- 1 QB decision:** Boston College transfer QB Dylan Lonergan has been named Rutgers' starting quarterback for Week 1.
- 2 ★ WR KJ Duff / RB Antwan Raymond:** WR KJ Duff (1,084 receiving yards) and RB Antwan Raymond (1,241 rushing yards, 15 TDs) give Rutgers two of the most proven offensive skill players in its tier.
- 3 2025 baseline:** The 2025 defense was genuinely poor across methods: total defense No.127, defensive EPA/play allowed No.123, success rate allowed No.131 and explosive-play rate allowed No.136.
- 4 Secondary rebuild:** The secondary is a full composition rebuild: both 12-start corners transferred, DB Cam Miller took a pro opportunity, and 12-start S Jett Elad left for the CFL's BC Lions.
- 5 Schedule pressure:** SP+ SOS is No.39 (7/10): Rutgers has UMass and Howard at home, but USC, Indiana, Michigan and Penn State create four games against top-17 SP+ opponents.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	5-7 (2-7 Big Ten)	● Poor
Scoring	28.7 PPG	● Average / mixed
Total offense	407.1 YPG	● Good / above average
Rush offense	141.0 YPG · 3.6 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass efficiency	8.42 YPA · 22 TD / 7 INT	● Very good
Third downs	42.5%	● Good / above average
Scoring defense	31.8 PPG allowed	● Poor
Total defense	432.8 YPG allowed	● Very poor
Rush defense	209.9 YPG · 6.8 YPC	● Very poor
Pass defense	222.9 YPG · 8.57 YPA · 23 TD allowed	● Very poor

Rutgers’ offense was functional-to-good by conventional measures, while the defense was a clear liability.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+1.89 · No. 54	● Average / mixed
Off. EPA/play	+0.099 · No. 29	● Very good
Off. success rate	45.7% · No. 36	● Good / above average
Off. explosive-play rate	11.1% · No. 98	● Below average
Havoc allowed	16.4% · No. 94	● Below average
Opp.-adjusted defense	-3.88 · No. 100	● Below average
Def. EPA/play allowed	+0.134 · No. 123	● Very poor
Def. success rate allowed	48.3% · No. 131	● Very poor
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	17.1% · No. 136	● Very poor
Havoc created	12.7% · No. 119	● Poor

Advanced-stat read: Rutgers was not a uniformly poor 5-7 team in 2025: the offense generated top-30 EPA/play and top-40 success rate, but it lacked explosive frequency and now changes QB/OL pieces. The defense was bad by every important efficiency lens-especially success rate, explosive prevention and havoc-so the 2026 evaluation turns on whether Johansen and the imported front can create a fast enough reset before an inexperienced secondary is exposed.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Greg Schiano - returning	● ↔ Greg Schiano's return keeps the program structure and defensive identity stable.
OC / offensive authority	Kirk Ciarrocca - returning OC/QBs; Schiano handoff language supports offensive operational/play-calling authority	● ↔ Kirk Ciarrocca returns with established offensive operational and play-calling authority.
DC / defensive operational leader	◆ Travis Johansen - new external hire from South Dakota HC	● ↑ Johansen brings new defensive leadership and a fresh structure to a unit that needs rapid improvement.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Dylan Lonergan	Boston College	● ↔ Won the QB1 job, but remains an unproven replacement for the drafted 2025 starter.

Out	To	Loss
QB Athan Kaliakmanis	NFL (Washington), Round 7, No. 223	● ↓ The 2025 starting quarterback and experienced distributor exits, increasing projection risk at the most important position.
WR Ian Strong	California	● ↓ A 10-start, 762-yard receiver leaves; WR KJ Duff remains elite, but proven complementary volume falls.
OT Taj White	Colorado	● ↓ Eleven starts at right tackle leave a line already replacing multiple established roles.
OL Bryan Felter	Undrafted; rookie-minicamp opportunity	● ↓ The 12-start left guard exits after documented rookie-minicamp opportunities.
C Gus Zilinskas	Undrafted; rookie-minicamp opportunity	● ↓ A 41-career-start center exits after documented rookie-minicamp opportunities, materially reducing OL continuity.

Offensive net: ● ↓ modest downgrade despite elite returning RB/WR anchors

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ EDGE/DL J'Dan Burnett	Tulsa	● ↑ Brings 9.5 TFL and 6.5 sacks from 2025 and is a major-role candidate in a front that needs disruption.
◆ EDGE/DL Malachi Davis	Toledo	● ↑ A 12-start edge with 9.5 TFL and 5.5 sacks adds proven production to the rebuild.
◆ LB Ty Morris	Rice	● ↑ Eighty-eight tackles and 9.5 TFL provide a credible high-volume LB addition.
◆ CB Kevyn Humes	Maryland	● ↔ Adds three prior starts and current-role evidence, but cannot by himself replace the volume lost from the veteran secondary.

Out	To	Loss
CB Bo Mascoe	Texas	● ↓ A 12-start, honorable-mention All-Big Ten corner departs.
CB Jacobie Henderson	Virginia	● ↓ The other 12-start corner departs, compounding the secondary reset.
S Jett Elad	CFL (BC Lions)	● ↓ The 12-start safety and 2025 team tackles leader left for the CFL's BC Lions.
EDGE Eric O'Neill	Undrafted; NFL opportunity; no signing established	● ↓ A 47-consecutive-start edge with 9.5 TFL in 2025 leaves after a documented NFL opportunity.

Defensive net: ● ↓ high-variance rebuild; front-seven additions help, but the secondary loses too much proven experience to call the unit upgraded

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	A Ciarrocca offense with proven RB/WR centerpieces, strong 2025 efficiency and named QB1 Dylan Lonergan.	RB Antwan Raymond's rushing volume plus WR KJ Duff's high-end receiving production; 2025 EPA/play and success rate were top-36.	Lonergan's transition and rebuilt OL can erase efficiency; the 2025 offense was only No.98 in explosive-play rate.
Defense	Johansen is expected to own the defense with an emphasis on fundamentals, physicality and effort, supported by imported front-seven production.	EDGE/DL J'Dan Burnett, EDGE/DL Malachi Davis and LB Ty Morris give the new staff credible disruption/tackle production.	The secondary rebuild follows a 2025 defense that was No.131 in success rate allowed and No.136 in explosive-play rate allowed.
Special teams	Continuity at kicker and punter, with a smaller operation-level question at long snapper.	K Jai Patel made 13 field goals and 37 PATs; P Jakob Anderson averaged 44.2 yards on 33 punts.	Primary long snapper is not established and Timmy Ward's multi-unit special-teams role departs.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	QB Dylan Lonergan has won the job but remains an unproven replacement for a drafted starter.
RB	● A-	● ↔	High	RB Antwan Raymond returns after 1,241 yards and 15 touchdowns as the offensive anchor.
WR	● B+	● ↓	Medium-high	WR KJ Duff is the star returner, but WR Ian Strong and other volume depart.
TE	● C	● ↓	Low	The room lacks an established anchor after meaningful veteran departures.
OL	● C+	● ↓	Low	RG Kwabena Asamoah is the clearest returning anchor in a line replacing multiple contributors.
DL/Edge	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	EDGE/DL J'Dan Burnett and transfer help offset front departures.
LB	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	LB Ty Morris adds production to a second level replacing meaningful volume.
Secondary	● C-	● ↓	Low	CB Kevyn Humes helps, but both 12-start corners and S Jett Elad depart.
Special teams	● B-	● ↔	Medium	K Jai Patel and P Flynn Appleby return, while long snapper remains unresolved.
Coaching	● B	● ↔	Medium	HC Greg Schiano and OC Kirk Ciarrocca return while the defensive coordinator changes.
Overall	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	Bowl-fringe profile with proven skill talent but major QB/OL/secondary uncertainty.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
KJ Duff	WR	● Nationally recognized star receiver	AP second-team All-America · Walter Camp second-team All-America · Big Ten honoree · Biletnikoff · Walter Camp POY	Returns after 1,084 receiving yards and is the offense's clearest high-end matchup piece.
Antwan Raymond	RB	● High-end conference starter	Big Ten honoree · Maxwell	Returns after 1,241 rushing yards and 15 touchdowns and can stabilize the offense while QB settles.
AJ Surace	QB	● Reserve quarterback / developmental upside	-	Finished behind Lonergan in the Week 1 competition; remains an important reserve.
◆ Dylan Lonergan (TR: Boston College)	QB	● Unproven transfer starter	-	Named Week 1 QB1 and remains the most important offensive newcomer.
Kwabena Asamoah	RG	● Proven returning OL anchor	-	The only clearly established returning 12-start OL anchor in a unit replacing major experience.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
♦ J'Dan Burnett (TR: Tulsa)	EDGE/DL	● Impact transfer / major-role candidate	-	Produced 9.5 TFL and 6.5 sacks in 2025 and gives the rebuilt defense needed edge disruption.
♦ Ty Morris (TR: Rice)	LB	● High-volume transfer starter candidate	-	Eighty-eight tackles and 9.5 TFL provide one of the most bankable production imports on defense.
♦ Kevyn Humes (TR: Maryland)	CB	● Starter/rotation projection in a rebuilt secondary	-	Has three prior Maryland starts and is one of the few identified experienced candidates replacing two 12-start corners.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Moderately difficult and top-heavy; the nonconference floor games help, but Rutgers must win most of the middle-tier Big Ten toss-ups to bowl.
Difficulty	● 7/10 · Hard · SP+ SOS No. 39
Hardest stretch	Michigan → at Wisconsin → Nebraska → at Penn State
Swing games	at Maryland, at Northwestern, at Wisconsin, Nebraska, Michigan State
Advantage	Home games with UMass and Howard provide two clear baseline wins on paper, and the Oct. 10 bye precedes a run of Big Ten swing games.
Expected	5.4 wins · most likely 5-7
Floor / ceiling	3-9 / 8-4

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Likely more attractive as an underdog when RB Antwan Raymond/WR KJ Duff can keep the offense on schedule than as a favorite priced as if the defense is already fixed.
Back them when	The matchup does not demand repeated obvious-passing downs and the opponent lacks a strong vertical/secondary stress profile; require extra margin until QB and secondary roles settle.
Fade/pass when	Against efficient passing offenses or strong fronts that can attack the rebuilt OL and force a new QB to win obvious passing downs.
Key monitor	Lonergan efficiency/backup snap plan, final OL five/center, secondary starters, Wydeek Collier-Johnson status
Week 1 baseline	rating-only fair baseline Rutgers –37.5 ; Rutgers primer +2.5 minus UMass final preseason SP+ proxy -32.9 plus 2.0 default home field; no matchup or availability adjustment Live market: Rutgers –29.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25) .

10. Summary

Rutgers has real offensive anchors in RB Antwan Raymond and WR KJ Duff, with QB Dylan Lonergan now the starter behind a rebuilt OL. The offense remains the clearest path to bowl eligibility, but QB efficiency is a major swing point.

The defense is the larger concern after a major secondary reset, even with front-seven reinforcements. The preseason baseline remains **5.4 wins · likely 5-7**, with the middle-tier Big Ten swing games deciding whether Rutgers reaches six.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching](#) · [departures](#) · [current update](#) · [QB1 update](#)

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